

Understanding Document – First Session

Session Learning Notes – Mahender Sivaraman 2025mb26147

The first session gave me a broader understanding of Product Management. It is not only about collecting requirements or managing a roadmap. It is about owning a problem, making decisions and being responsible for the outcome.

Key Points I Understood

- A Product Manager should think of themselves as the CEO of the product.
- The Product Manager owns the problem and the outcome, even though different teams execute the work.
- The role connects the customer, market, business, technology, design and other functions.
- The Product Manager may also have responsibility without having direct authority over every team.
- Listening to different opinions is important, but someone still has to take the final call.
- Product Management involves continuous decision-making and judgment.
- There is usually no single perfect answer in management; decisions depend on the situation and assumptions.
- Trade-offs are unavoidable because time, money, people and skills are limited.
- A technically advanced solution may not always be the best product decision if it creates practical problems later.
- A Product Manager needs customer judgment, business judgment and enough technical understanding to make informed decisions.
- Technical fluency is especially important when managing AI products.
- Product responsibility does not end at launch. Adoption, business results, product improvement and future versions also matter.
- Product managers may have to sunset an old version or even decide that the entire product should be discontinued.
- The meaning of 'done' can be different depending on the situation. AI products make this decision more difficult because the environment keeps changing.
- AI can be used to build a product, to help with Product Management work, or to become part of the product experienced by customers.
- Using AI does not remove the need for human judgment. The Product Manager still has to decide what should be built and why.
- Frameworks are useful for supporting decisions. The objective is not to memorise frameworks but to choose an appropriate one for the problem.
- An MBA helps because Product Management requires an integrated view of business, finance, marketing, operations, customers and technology.
- The role can be stressful because there is ambiguity, difficult conversations and accountability without complete control.
- At the same time, successfully building something useful can create a strong sense of achievement and pride.
- Participation and reflection are important because personal understanding is more useful than simply summarising the class.
- The changing AI environment should be treated as something to learn and work with rather than something that can simply be ignored.

Takeaway on today's session.

My main takeaway is that a Product Manager is ultimately a decision maker and an owner. The role requires balancing customer needs, business value, technology and available resources. For AI products, I think this becomes even more important because the technology and possibilities are changing quickly. I should therefore focus on understanding the reasoning behind decisions rather than just learning definitions or frameworks.